

Chapter 113-5

Qi Jiao, who was hunched over her desk doing homework, had been secretly glancing at her. She caught all of Chen Mian's actions in her peripheral vision, feeling scared and anxious. After a moment, Chen Mian carried that box of chocolate over and tossed it on Qi Jiao's desk. Frowning, her voice flat and her manner insufferably arrogant, she said, "This stuff is too gross. So bitter. Don't give me any more."

Qi Jiao felt very sad when she heard this. She sat in her seat as if sitting on pins and needles, not knowing what to do.

Her diary entry that day was also very sad. She said she really hadn't meant to—that box of chocolates was very expensive, a four-digit price.

She even added a line to this diary entry the next morning: 【You made me cry all night, bad Chen Mian. But I still can't bring myself to dislike you.】

But the next day, Chen Mian placed a box of chocolates and a box of milk candies on her desk. During break, Chen Mian said to her, "When you eat things, eat sweet ones. Don't eat that bitter stuff. No wonder you always look like you're at a funeral."

Qi Jiao was in a daze all day because of those words.

And in return, at lunchtime, she bought Chen Mian a chicken drumstick.

At that time, she was eating alone in the cafeteria, and so was Chen Mian.

They had both eaten many meals alone and quietly, but Chen Mian sat in her spot for a long time, not touching her own food tray. Finally, she carried her tray and went to sit across from Qi Jiao.

This was the first time Qi Jiao had someone sitting across from her when eating at school.

Chen Mian wasn't a patient good companion. She spoke little, had a bad temper, and occasionally cursed.

But in Qi Jiao's eyes, she was genuine.

Chen Mian was only quiet when painting. She was born with the talent to be a painter. Her paintings were wild and imaginative, as if free souls were leaping onto the paper.

It was the brush leading her hand to paint, not her holding the brush.

Qi Jiao once asked Chen Mian why she liked painting so much.

Chen Mian said it was because she didn't like talking.

Qi Jiao and Chen Mian were nothing more than simple playmates—at least that's how it was defined in Qi Jiao's diary. She had no other friends, so she could only play with Chen Mian.

Chen Mian would occasionally ignore her, and when Yang Jiani appeared, even if Qi Jiao saw Chen Mian, she would quickly walk away without acknowledging the looks Chen Mian sent her way.

Whether confused or pleasantly surprised.

In a way, they were indeed suited to be playmates.

Both would abandon the other at different times.

Qi Jiao discovered that she liked Chen Mian when Chen Mian started getting close to an upperclassman.

That upperclassman was the daughter of Chen Mian's painting teacher. She was gentle, pretty, and had good temperament. When talking with Chen Mian, Chen Mian would rarely show a shy expression and would occasionally blush.

Qi Jiao had only seen them walking together from afar—beautiful and serene.

The afterglow of the sunset enveloped them, an emotion Qi Jiao would never have in her lifetime.

And Qi Jiao was also caught by Chen Mian secretly watching Liang Shi. The only person Qi Jiao ever confided in was Chen Mian.

The first time she drank alcohol was with Chen Mian. After drinking too much, her face was flushed red. She quietly whispered in Chen Mian's ear, "I have a little sister."

She said her sister was from different parents on both sides¹. Her sister was like a little angel, with a pair of very beautiful light brown eyes. She had a sweet and adorable personality and would sweetly call her "sister."

The diary entry went on here, then the focus shifted back to Liang Shi.

Qi Jiao said Liang Shi's personality had changed now. She could protect herself. This was truly something worth being happy about.

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Qi Jiao's diary was expansive, with all the beautiful brushstrokes reserved for Chen Mian and Liang Shi.

After reading through it once more, Liang Shi pulled out her phone and opened WeChat. She had cleared her contacts once before, so she might have already deleted Chen Mian.

She carefully looked through her list and found a profile picture mixed among the many contacts.

A girl wearing a white dress stood in a hazy moon.

This was a difficult painting to execute—the slightest mistake would make the color contrast look ugly.

But Chen Mian had painted it very well. It was almost identical to the one Chen Mian had given the original owner according to her memories.

And her WeChat name was: J.

The "Jiao" from Qi Jiao.

That was how Liang Shi interpreted it.

She tapped into the chat and sent Chen Mian a message: 【Are you there? Chen Mian.】

She directly called her by name.

A moment later, Chen Mian replied: 【?】

The brief question mark was Chen Mian's typical style.

Liang Shi: 【Are you in Haizhou City? Let's meet.】

Chen Mian: 【I'm in Country Y.】

This single sentence completely blocked off what Liang Shi wanted to say.

She wanted to meet Chen Mian and ask whether Chen Mian understood Qi Jiao's state of mind before she jumped off the building.

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Liang Shi really wanted to know what Qi Jiao had experienced in the days before she chose to jump. The diary entries from that period were all vague and unclear.

Chen Mian's tone was distant. Liang Shi didn't push and sent her: 【Sorry to bother you.】

Attempting to end the conversation with this.

But then Chen Mian said: 【I'm returning to the country next week. Let's meet then.】

Liang Shi immediately replied: 【Okay.】

Chen Mian had never deleted Liang Shi from her WeChat, and she replied quickly to her messages.

It was probably related to Qi Jiao.

Thinking of the recording she had heard, Liang Shi increasingly felt there was something between Qi Jiao and Chen Mian.

It didn't seem quite like what was shown in the diary.

Liang Shi carefully put away Qi Jiao's diary, then drove to the kindergarten. On the way to the kindergarten, a staff member from the "Mo Guang"² production crew called to notify her that her scenes would start filming on Wednesday. She must arrive at the crew by 7 AM on Wednesday to begin hair and makeup.

Liang Shi acknowledged with an okay.

On one hand, she lamented that she hadn't rested a single day since coming here, spinning like a wound-up clock. On the other hand, she thought about how many days were left until her tasks ended.

She felt like these tasks were endless.

Liang Shi waited at the kindergarten entrance for a while and soon it was time for kindergarten to let out.

She saw Su Yao who had come to pick up Sheng Yu, greeted her, and politely inquired about how she was doing.

Su Yao answered each question.

As for Rainbow, she still had no one picking her up. Zhou Li was busy with work and would leave Rainbow at the kindergarten under the supervision of the teacher on duty.

Seeing Rainbow all alone, Liang Shi picked her up too.

When Ling Dang saw it was Liang Shi picking her up, she curiously asked, "Auntie, where's my mommy?"

"I don't know." Liang Shi scooped her up in one motion. "Big Uncle asked me to take you back to the old residence."

Upon hearing the words "old residence," Ling Dang shrank back, somewhat resistant. "Let's... not?"

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1. "Different parents on both sides" (異父異母) means they share neither the same father nor the same mother—in other words, they are not biologically related at all. Qi Jiao considered Liang Shi her "sister" even though they had no blood relation. ⇐
 2. "Mo Guang" (《餘光》) literally means "Lingering Light" or "Peripheral Vision"—this is the name of the drama/film production that Liang Shi is participating in. ⇐